Philosophy · Metaphysics of God

Ontological Arguments

Student workbook · Anselm, Gaunilo, Descartes and Malcolm

This workbook goes alongside the two lesson presentations: **The Ontological Argument** (Anselm, Gaunilo and Descartes) and **Malcolm's ontological argument**. Work through it one Part at a time. Every task can be completed from the slides and your class notes.

Name

Class / teacher

IN THIS WORKBOOK

1. Foundations — a priori arguments, necessary and contingent
2. Anselm's ontological argument
3. Gaunilo's perfect island and Anselm's replies
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6. Evaluating Malcolm
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How to use this workbook

Symbol	What it means
Short	One or two lines. A definition, a fact or a single step.
Medium	Three to six lines. Explain a step and the reason for it.
Table	Fill in the empty cells. Use short phrases, not full paragraphs.
Sort / Order	Put the pieces in the right order or the right group.

Symbol	What it means
Exam	Timed, exam-style question. Lined space is provided.

Key idea Missed a lesson? Every Part starts with a short **Recap** box. Read it, then go back to the matching slides before you try the tasks.

Part 01 Foundations

Recap

The ontological argument is an **a priori** argument for the existence of God. It starts with a definition of God, then unpacks the idea of God to prove that God exists.

A priori arguments do not need recourse to experience of the external world in order to prove a conclusion.

Task 1 · Table Complete the key terms table. Use the slides to help you.

Key term	Definition in my own words	Example or link to the argument
A priori		
Ontological argument		
Necessary being / truth		
Contingent being / truth		
Analytic		
Synthetic		
Predicate / property		
Reductio ad absurdum		

Key term	Definition in my own words	Example or link to the argument
Coherent concept		

Task 2 · Sort Is each statement **necessary** (a contradiction to deny) or **contingent** (not a contradiction to deny)? Tick one column and give a reason.

Statement	Necessary	Contingent	Why?
2 + 2 = 4			
There are 8 planets in the solar system.			
All bachelors are unmarried men.			
223798 + 1232131 = 1455929			
This classroom exists.			

Task 3 · Short The slides give **two assumptions** behind the ontological argument. Write them out.

3a Assumption 1:

3b Assumption 2:

Task 4 · Medium Why does it matter that the ontological argument is **a priori**? What would it mean for the argument if it succeeded?

Part 02 Anselm's ontological argument

Recap

Anselm understood theology to be 'faith seeking understanding'. He defines God as 'something than which nothing greater can be thought'.

Because of this, the slides note that Anselm's argument is theological and not strictly philosophical.

> *'you who grant understanding to faith…you are, as we believe you are, and that you are what we believe you to be'*
>
> — Anselm, Proslogion (as quoted in the lesson slides)

Task 5 · Order Fill in the missing words to complete Anselm's argument.

Step	Anselm's argument
1	God is something than which _____ can be thought.
2	Something than which nothing greater can be thought exists in the _____.
3	It is something which 'can be thought to exist in _____ as well, which is _____'.
4	Something than which nothing greater can be thought must therefore exist in _____.
5	Therefore, _____.

Task 6 · Medium Explain the **painter analogy**. How does it help us understand the difference between existing 'in the understanding' and existing 'in reality'?

Task 7 · Short Anselm then adds a further inference. Complete it.

Something that exists _____ is greater than something which exists

_____. So God exists _____.

Task 8 · Medium In your own words, explain why step 3 is the key step in Anselm's argument.

Task 9 · Draw Draw a simple flow diagram of Anselm's argument in the box: idea of God → in the understanding → in reality. Add one word on each arrow to say what moves the argument on.

Part 03 Gaunilo's perfect island and Anselm's replies

Recap

The slides note two objections to Anselm's argument: (1) that we cannot think about the greatest possible being; (2) that even if we could, it would not prove the existence of God.

Gaunilo asks us to imagine the most excellent island. If Anselm's reasoning worked, it would prove that this island exists too. This is a **reductio ad absurdum** — a reduction to absurdity.

Task 10 · Short What is a **reductio ad absurdum**? Why is Gaunilo's island an example of one?

Task 11 · Table Lay out Gaunilo's argument so that it mirrors Anselm's, step by step.

Step	Anselm's version (God)	Gaunilo's version (the island)
1	God is that than which nothing greater can be thought.	
2	This exists in the understanding.	
3	Existing in reality as well is greater.	
4	So God exists in reality.	
Absurd?		

Task 12 · Table Summarise Anselm's replies to Gaunilo.

Anselm's reply	What it says	Which objection (1 or 2) does it answer?
We can think of the greatest possible being		
Ideas can 'misfire'		
Existence is an 'intrinsic property' of the idea of God		
The idea of an island		

Task 13 · Table Anselm's distinction: complete the table.

	Empty intuition	Categorical intuition
What happens		
Example		
Link to the person who thinks they are thinking of God		

Task 14 · Medium Anselm says existence is part of the idea of God 'just as lines are an essential part of … a triangle'. Explain the comparison, and say why an island is different.

Part 04 Descartes' ontological argument

Recap

Descartes starts with a very specific definition of God: a **supremely perfect being**.

> *'The idea of God (that is of a supremely perfect being) is certainly one that I find within me…; and I understand from this idea that it belongs to God's nature that he always exists.'*
>
> — Descartes (as quoted in the lesson slides)

Task 15 · Order The five steps of Descartes' argument are jumbled. Number them 1–5 in the boxes.

Order	Statement
	A supremely perfect being does not lack any perfection.
	Therefore, God exists.

Order	Statement
	I have the idea of God.
	Existence is a perfection.
	The idea of God is the idea of a supremely perfect being.

Task 16 · Medium Which premise is the most important? Explain why the argument fails if that premise is removed.

Task 17 · Medium **Problem:** if God exists necessarily, how is it possible to doubt his existence? Explain how the maths example (223798 + 1232131) is meant to answer this.

Task 18 · Table Complete the comparison of Anselm and Descartes.

	Anselm	Descartes
Definition of God		
Key premise about existence		
Claim about necessary existence		

	Anselm	Descartes
Analogy used		

Task 19 · Table The objections. Complete each row.

Objection	What it claims	Which premise does it attack?
Kant		
Hume (1)		
Hume (2)		

Key idea Kant's objection matters twice: it attacks Descartes here, and Malcolm's whole argument is built as a reply to it.

Part 05 Malcolm's ontological argument

Recap

Norman Malcolm, 'Anselm's ontological arguments', is a reply to Kant. Malcolm argues that Anselm gave **two arguments**, not one, and that the second survives Kant.

The key move is the distinction between **existence** and **necessary existence**.

Task 20 · Table Malcolm on Anselm's two comparisons.

	First comparison	Second comparison
What is compared?		
Is it about what exists, or about kinds of existence?		

	First comparison	Second comparison
Does it survive Kant? Why?		

Task 21 · Table What does Malcolm concede to Kant, and what does he resist?

Conceded to Kant	Resisted

Task 22 · Medium Why might **necessary existence** behave differently from **existence**? (This is the annotation question on the slides.)

Task 23 · Order Number this chain of reasoning 1–4. It is what licenses P2 and P3.

Order	Step
	So God cannot depend on anything for coming into existence, or for staying in existence.
	'God is the greatest possible being' is a logically necessary truth — part of our concept of God.
	Therefore God's existence cannot depend on anything at all.
	A being that depends on something else for its existence is not as great as one whose existence is completely independent.

Key idea The 2023 Examiner Report (7172/2, Q02) says many students left out the **starting conception of God** — the 'bedrock' from which God's necessity is derived. Step 1 of this chain is that bedrock. Never leave it out.

Task 24 · Table Malcolm's two suppositions.

	Suppose God exists	Suppose God does not exist
What follows?		
Why?		
Conclusion		

Task 25 · Order Rebuild the whole argument. Write the label (P1–P6, C1–C5) next to each line, in the correct order. Cover the slides first and see how far you get.

Label	Statement
	Therefore, God's existence is either necessary or impossible.
	God cannot come into existence or go out of existence.
	The concept of God is not self-contradictory.
	Therefore, if God does not exist, God's existence is impossible.
	Either God exists or God does not exist.
	Therefore, God exists necessarily.
	If God exists, God cannot cease to exist.
	God's existence is impossible only if the concept of God is self-contradictory.
	Therefore, if God exists, God's existence is necessary.
	Therefore, God's existence is not impossible.
	If God does not exist, God cannot come into existence.

Task 26 · Short Answer the three annotation questions from the slides.

26a Which premises are definitions, or come straight from the concept of God?

26b Which premises are contested?

26c Where does the argument move from 'if' to 'is'?

Task 27 · Table The distinction the argument depends on. Fill in the blank column without looking, then check.

	Existence (contingent)	Necessary existence
Is it a property?	No — Kant's point, which Malcolm accepts.	
Type of judgement	'God exists' is treated as synthetic.	
What it tells us	That a thing happens to be.	
Dependence	Depends on something else for coming into or staying in existence.	

Task 28 · Medium Malcolm's reply to Kant. First explain Kant's **conditional reading** ('if God exists, then God exists necessarily'). Then explain why Malcolm says this is confused.

Kant's conditional reading

Malcolm's response

Part 06 Evaluating Malcolm

Recap

Malcolm's argument has real strengths, but it faces two objections: one against **P6** (is the concept of God coherent?) and a more serious one against **P5** (God's existence could be impossible without the concept being self-contradictory).

Task 29 · Table Strengths of Malcolm's argument. Explain each in your own words, then rate how strong you think it is (1 = weak, 5 = strong).

Strength	Explanation	Rating 1–5
Answers Kant on Kant's own terms		
Identifies a real distinction		
A priori and deductive		
The burden of proof point		

Task 30 · Medium **Objection 1 (P6).** Who should carry the burden of proof — the theist, to show the concept of God is coherent, or the critic, to show it is incoherent? Give a reason for your view.

Task 31 · Order **Objection 2 (P5).** Put the four steps of the objection in order (1–4).

Order	Step
	Therefore P5 is false: God's existence could be impossible without the concept of God being self-contradictory.
	Necessary existence is the type of existence God has if God exists; God's existence does not depend on anything.
	This is a different impossibility: the contradiction lies in the idea of bringing into existence something that depends on nothing — not in the concept of God.
	If God does not exist, God cannot be brought into existence. In this sense God's existence is impossible.

Task 32 · Medium Explain why, if P5 fails, **C4 collapses**. What is 'all that Malcolm's argument establishes'?

Task 33 · Table Evaluation at a glance. Complete the final column with your own judgement and one reason.

Premise	Challenge	My judgement: how strong is the challenge?
P2 / P3	Rest on 'God is the greatest possible being' being a logically necessary truth.	
P5	God's existence can be impossible without the concept of God being self-contradictory.	
P6	Malcolm offers no general proof that the concept of God is coherent.	
C5	Only conditional conclusions follow from the argument.	

Task 34 · Medium **Your verdict.** In three or four sentences: does Malcolm's argument prove that God exists? Name the premise that decides it for you.

Part 07 Exam practice

What the examiners want

3 marks: a precise definition, no evaluation.

5 marks: a short, accurate explanation with the steps in order.

12 marks: explanation (AO1), not evaluation. A precise, accurate and detailed account, integrated into a clear argument. Premises in the right order, the reasoning between them made explicit, technical vocabulary used correctly. No objections unless the question asks for them.

Short exam questions

35 Explain what is meant by 'necessary existence'. **[3 marks]**

36 Explain the distinction Malcolm draws between the claim 'God exists' and the claim 'God exists necessarily'. **[3 marks]**

37 Explain why Malcolm claims that God's existence is either necessary or impossible. **[5 marks]**

38 Explain Malcolm's reply to Kant's objection to ontological arguments. **[5 marks]**

39 Outline Norman Malcolm's ontological argument. **[5 marks]**

Key idea Question 39 was set in June 2023 (7172/2, Q02). The 2023 Examiner Report says it was the hardest 5-mark question on the paper. Students who reached 5 marks deduced God's necessity from a **conception of God** — for example Anselm's 'a being greater than which nothing can be conceived'. Weaker answers confused it with cosmological arguments from contingency.

Part 07 12 mark question 40

Explain Malcolm's ontological argument for the existence of God. [12 marks]

Task 40a · Plan Plan your answer using the paragraph scaffold. Write key words only.

Paragraph	Key words for my answer
1 Set out the aim	Ontological argument · concept of God · a priori
2 The distinction	Accepts Kant on existence · necessary existence is different
3 No dependence	Greatest possible being · dependent being is not greatest
4 The dilemma	P1–C3: necessary or impossible
5 Close the dilemma	P5 + P6 → C4 → C5
6 Finish on the logic	

Task 40b · Exam Write your answer. Aim for about 25 minutes.

Self-check before you hand in

- ☐ I stated the starting conception of God.
- ☐ My steps are in the right order and each one leads to the next.
- ☐ I used technical vocabulary correctly (a priori, analytic, necessary, contingent, predicate).
- ☐ I did not evaluate or add objections, because the question did not ask for them.

Part 07

12 mark question 41

Explain why Malcolm argues that necessary existence, unlike existence, can be a property. [12 marks]

Task 41a · Plan Plan your answer using the paragraph scaffold. Write key words only.

Paragraph	Key words for my answer
1 Kant's objection	
2 What Malcolm concedes	
3 The second comparison	
4 Analytic, not synthetic	
5 Reply to the conditional reading	
6 Conclusion	

Task 41b · Exam Write your answer. Aim for about 25 minutes.

Self-check before you hand in

- ☐ I stated the starting conception of God.
- ☐ My steps are in the right order and each one leads to the next.
- ☐ I used technical vocabulary correctly (a priori, analytic, necessary, contingent, predicate).
- ☐ I did not evaluate or add objections, because the question did not ask for them.

Part 07

12 mark question 42

Explain Gaunilo's perfect island objection to Anselm's ontological argument and how Anselm responds. [12 marks]

Task 42a · Plan Plan your answer using the paragraph scaffold. Write key words only.

Paragraph	Key words for my answer
1 Anselm's argument	
2 Gaunilo's island	
3 Why it is a reductio	
4 Reply: we can think it	
5 Reply: intrinsic property	
6 Island vs God	

Task 42b · Exam Write your answer. Aim for about 25 minutes.

Self-check before you hand in

- ☐ I stated the starting conception of God.
- ☐ My steps are in the right order and each one leads to the next.
- ☐ I used technical vocabulary correctly (a priori, analytic, necessary, contingent, predicate).
- ☐ I did not evaluate or add objections, because the question did not ask for them.

Part 08 Progress check

Task 43 · Table Rate your confidence now (1 = not yet, 3 = secure). Go back to the matching Part for any 1s.

I can…	Part	1	2	3
define a priori, necessary and contingent	1			
set out Anselm's argument in five steps	2			
explain Gaunilo's island and Anselm's replies	3			
set out Descartes' argument and the objections	4			
explain Malcolm's two comparisons	5			
write out P1–C5 from memory	5			
explain Malcolm's reply to Kant	5			
explain the P5 objection and why C4 collapses	6			
plan a 12 mark answer without evaluation	7			

Task 44 · Medium The one thing I still find hardest is… and my plan to fix it is…